catch Chimpu, Dada took a miscalculated dive and ended up almost crushing Chimpu, who then let out two or three feeble cries and ran inside on three legs instead of four. ‘Dada . . . Timpu . . . no,’ was all I could manage to say to Dada. I understood that he had hurt Chimpu. Dada pulled up his knickers and gestured with a finger on his lips, hoping I would stay quiet. He tiptoed to take a look at Papaji and saw him dozing in the chair, a book in his hand. Dada then tilted his head and gestured for me to follow him inside the house. I trod softly behind him in my flowery pyjamas. We saw Chimpu lying on his mattress, licking his front right paw, the one that was hurt. On seeing this, I curled up my lower lip and frowned at Dada. ‘Sorry Gunju, I didn’t mean it,’ Dada said. ‘Let’s make his pain go away. Okay?’ I understood him and nodded. He then cupped his chin and began to think. I imitated him and cupped my chin too. A scared Chimpu looked at us as we devised another devilry.

For a while we stood there, doing nothing. Then I saw something that reminded me of Papaji’s remedy. Two nights ago, Maa had twisted her ankle at Colonel Usha’s place after dinner. Upon reaching home, I had seen Papaji massage Maa’s ankle with something in a red glass bottle. I could see that bottle on the kitchen shelf. I tugged at Dada’s arm and pulled him inside the kitchen. ‘What is it?’ he asked. I pointed towards the bottle and said, ‘Dada . . . botil . . . Chimpu pain go.’ He, too, understood what I meant, and since he was taller than me, had to go get the bottle. Somehow, he managed. The bottle was uncorked and a hand towel was made to soak in most of its contents. I covered my nose with one hand—the smell was sharp, pungent. I ran to Chimpu with the towel and started to wipe his right paw with it. Unsure, Dada watched me doing it. Chimpu’s fur was soaked in the liquid from the towel and he started to lick it. After a while, Chimpu got up—on all fours. I smiled, thinking my remedy had worked. Chimpu snatched the towel from my hand and began to lick it too. I looked at Dada with a smile of victory.

A confused Dada stared at Chimpu, who kept licking the towel for the next few minutes until his hind legs dwindled a little and he fell sideways. However, he managed to get up and dash outside, zigzagging, trying hard to